Following lectures and extended explanations

Practical guide for students | D03-ST

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Focus on the main ideas and how they connect. If you miss a word or sentence, try to rejoin the explanation rather than translating everything you missed.

1. Preview the topic

Check the lesson outline, slides or assigned preparation if available. Identify the main topic and a few important terms. Think about what you already know and what you want to understand.

2. Listen for the structure

Notice phrases that show where the explanation is going:

- "Today we'll look at three factors…" introduces the structure.
- "The main point is…" highlights an important idea.
- "For example…" introduces an illustration.
- "However…" signals a contrast.
- "To summarise…" brings the main ideas together.

3. Connect explanations with visuals

Use headings, diagrams, graphs and key terms to follow the explanation. Notice which part your teacher is discussing and how it relates to the main idea.

If the connection is unclear, ask: "Could you explain how this diagram connects to that point?"

4. Separate main ideas from examples

Ask yourself: “What idea is this example helping to explain?”

You do not need to remember every detail of an example. Focus on the subject concept and how the example illustrates it.

5. Mark a gap and keep listening

If you lose track, mark a question or a few words to remind yourself what was unclear. Listen for the next heading, key term or summary so you can rejoin.

Ask for clarification at an appropriate pause. For example:

“I understood the explanation of revenue, but I missed how it connects to profit. Could you explain that again?”

6. Check your understanding afterwards

Use the slides, reading or your notes to explain the main ideas in your own words. Identify any gap that remains and ask your teacher a focused question. You can compare your understanding with a classmate, then check uncertain points against course materials.

Example

What the teacher says “Revenue increased this month. However, profit fell because costs rose faster than revenue. For example, ingredient and staffing costs both increased.”

Part of the explanation	What to notice
“However”	A contrast is coming.
“Profit fell because costs rose faster than revenue”	The main relationship being explained.
Ingredient and staffing costs	Examples of the increased costs.

My summary “Higher revenue does not always mean higher profit. Profit can fall if costs increase by more than revenue.”

7. Check your understanding

- I can identify the main topic and key points.
- I can explain how the main ideas connect.
- I can distinguish an example from the idea it illustrates.
- I know which points I still need to clarify.

If you regularly struggle to follow explanations: discuss a specific example with your teacher. Explain where you lost track and what you tried. Ask about relevant subject or English-language support.

Supporting sources

Monash University. (n.d.). *Listening to lectures*. Student Academic Success. https://www.monash.edu/student-academic-success/improve-your-academic-english/strategies-for-listening-and-reading/listening-to-academic-english/listening-to-lectures

Supports previewing topics and slides, listening for main and supporting points, recognising signposting, and continuing to listen when a word or idea is missed.

University of Reading. (2026). *Getting the most from your lectures*. https://libguides.reading.ac.uk/lectures/lectures

Supports preparing before lectures, recognising clues to important ideas, rejoining an explanation after losing track, and reviewing understanding independently and with peers. See “Preparing for your lectures”, “Active listening and note-making” and “Reviewing and retaining information”.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Listening*. https://ccaps.umn.edu/esl-resources/students/listening

Supports activating prior knowledge, previewing vocabulary and slides, asking focused clarification questions, and identifying gaps afterwards. See “Before Listening”, “While Listening” and “After Listening”.